

The Blue-tick Blues

They used to flaunt their verification tick marks. Now it's our turn!

Boo-Man | boo@digit.in

Remember the time when having that blue tick mark next to your name on Twitter meant something? Well, Mr Elon Musk, *in all his glory*, after taking over the reins of one of the most popular microblogging platforms on planet Earth, decided to be a bit charitable. He decided for a meagre fee of \$8 per month or \$84 once a year, everyone could get a blue tick next to their name. He very aptly called this service Twitter Blue.

I loved this idea. There was a barage of users – with insane amounts of money in their accounts, I guess? – who took to the platform and started impersonating brands. It had an adverse effect on the brands' images, and in some cases, brands even incurred actual monetary losses. Still, it was fun to watch. Then Twitter went back and added a bunch of new verification levels before someone could get their hands on the once-valued blue tick next to their name. Aww.

Despite all the potential fun that came with the new blue service, people frowned upon Twitter Blue. But I think that it will teach everyone an important lesson. A lesson about doing research. Now, instead of just seeing the blue tick next to a user name and re-Tweeting a post, people will be forced to take a detour and verify if the verified profile is actually legit or not.

Now the service is in India! And for me, nothing could be better than to see Mithun, who once roamed around the Mumbai office showing off his "legacy" blue tick, being annoyed into oblivion

Me: Mom, I need a verified Twitter account

Mom: No, we already have a verified account at home!

The account at home:



by a bunch of others around him, who, just for fun, bought the Twitter Blue subscription for a month. I know I know... there is a way for people to check if a profile was Twitter Blue verified or had a legacy verification.

So, coming back to showering my love on Twitter Blue. No matter how many of you frown upon me loving the shiny new tick next to my name as soon as I save up enough for it. Think of the millions of other users who were being tormented by the ones who were already verified on Twitter. There are a hundred different ways in which this will be misused. AND IT IS BAD.

But the average Billy from downtown Ohio or Prakrit from SoBo (South Bombay) will now need to research, read, and understand what an actual verified source is, before

plunging into a debate just because they read an argument about it posted from a verified handle on Twitter. When I wrote about climate change, I had booed people who just read a couple of research papers supporting their opinion before going head-on with someone in a debate. Now, I will be happy if people came in with some research and not comments taken from 'new-blue' Twitterati.

Things will change across the whole vertical of Indian society with Twitter Blue coming in. We have seen a trailer of what can happen with all that went down in the west. And it will be interesting to see how things pan out in India. It would be something like this:

If you are thinking that this will just be a gimmick used by people to have fun, then I think you're probably headed in the right direction. But Twitter will need to ensure that the sanctity of their verification system is untarnished. With AI content generation coming in, it will be even more difficult. Mr Musk has been very active, and we will need to come to terms with the rise of a new Twitter. For all of you thinking otherwise, I have one thing to say – "OK BOOMER". Ah, the Irony.

Now that you are here, and I am running out of space, you know what I am going to do. I will make sure to flash my new verification check mark on my profile and rub it into Mr BarbarianMonkey/Paranoid Android's face. However, I will need to keep my moves in check because no one else will want to hire a lazy writer who just complains about everything and always goes against the flow. If you don't see this section over here next month, you know what has happened. It will be one of two things – I will be on LinkedIn searching for a job, or AI will be writing Boo-Man and I will be sitting on a beach sipping coconut water. Either way, that's me singing off for now. 